Soviet and Bulgarian canned goods and preserves. The parallel market functioned until the Rectification Campaign in 1986. “My oldest son was born in 1980, and grew up full of Eastern Europe,” a colleague explained. “My younger son didn’t – he was born in 1986!”[53]

Until the Special Period, the distribution system – along with other changes that increased food availability on and off the ration – contributed to a drastic shift in Cuba’s health profile. Instead of the malnutrition that had plagued the poor prior to the Revolution, the most common diet-related diseases became obesity, hypertension, heart disease, and diabetes. An informant explained to one health researcher what Cubans like to eat: “Meat!! We like to eat pork. Beans and rice of course. But here we cook the beans and rice with lard and oil also. Everything has to be fried – chicken, plantains, malanga, and potatoes. We eat lots of food with flour – bread, spaghetti, pizza, crackers … We use lots of salt and sugar in our food. And we don’t eat many vegetables or fruits. And then there is the alcohol and the sodas.”[54]

Nutritionist Medea Benjamin and her colleagues noted that culture and politics interfered with any attempt to promote a less fatty and more plant-based diet. “Government leaders themselves are not totally convinced that the diet needs changing,” they explain. “Many of the officials we interviewed [in the early 1980s] seemed to accept uncritically the ‘modern’ western diet as superior. Take the question of animal versus vegetable protein. We discussed this in our interview with Vice President Rodriguez, and while he recognized that animal protein may not be better nutritionally or economically, he saw it as associated with development. ‘We don’t support the idea that has been tossed around in international circles that developed countries are going to have animal protein while developing countries get vegetable protein,’ he told us.”[55]

Notes

1 Bunck, *Quest for a Revolutionary Culture in Cuba*, p. xi.

2 Fernandes, *Cuba Represent!*, p. 2.